

Part 1

Application and Proofs

1 How do I apply for SNAP benefits?

You have the right to apply for benefits – whether or not DTA thinks you are eligible. This is a fundamental right of all Massachusetts residents. The SNAP rules require DTA to encourage individuals who ask about SNAP to apply. [106 C.M.R. §361.130](#). DTA still needs to determine if you are eligible, but no one should discourage you from filing a SNAP application.

There is NO wrong door! You can apply:

- Online on [DTAConnect.com](#) from a computer or smartphone.
- In person at any local DTA office:
 - The DTA office must accept your SNAP application the same day you walk in. [106 C.M.R. §361.130](#).
 - If you go in person, the local office should screen you for expedited (emergency) SNAP, offer to do an interview, give you an EBT card and accept any forms or documents you bring in. See **Question 3** about expedited SNAP.
- By phone:
 - Call the DTA Assistance Line at (877) 382-2363 and press #7 (currently the option for other languages). It may be very difficult to get through. Learn how to get help when you can't get through [here](#).
 - If you are age 60 or older, call the Senior Assistance Office at (833) 712-8027. See **Question 25**.
- Through your healthcare application or renewal:
 - When you apply for or renew your MassHealth or Medicare Savings Program (MSP) coverage, you can check the “apply for SNAP” checkbox. Your healthcare application is immediately sent to DTA for follow up, including a SNAP interview.

- Through a SNAP outreach provider by contacting:
 - A local SNAP Outreach Provider, list available here: [Mass.gov/snap-outreach](https://www.mass.gov/snap-outreach). Many local Councils on Aging and food pantries, as well as the Food Bank of Western MA and The Greater Boston Food Bank, do SNAP enrollment.
 - The Project Bread Food Source Hotline: 1-800-645-8333.
- Mailing or faxing to DTA a paper application:
 - Paper SNAP applications in multiple languages. Go to [Mass.gov/lists/snap-benefit-application](https://www.mass.gov/lists/snap-benefit-application). See **Question 15**.
 - Adults 60 or older can fill out a shorter “SNAP Application for Seniors.” Go to [Mass.gov/lists/snap-application-for-seniors](https://www.mass.gov/lists/snap-application-for-seniors).
 - If you want DTA to mail you a paper application, DTA should put one in the mail the same day you ask for it. [106 C.M.R. §361.140](#)

See SNAP application rights: [106 C.M.R. §361.080 et seq.](#)

Your right to apply with minimal information

You have the right to *file* a SNAP application with just your basic information: your name, address, signature and the date. [106 C.M.R. §361.130](#). You will still need to give DTA more information later, but don’t delay filing a SNAP application because you don’t have all the information or proofs.

If you already have a working EBT card

The SNAP application asks if you already have a Massachusetts EBT card. If you have one with your name on it, you can use it once your SNAP case is approved. If you tell DTA you do not have an EBT card - or if you don’t answer the question and you have not been on SNAP recently - DTA will mail you a card. You can also go to the local DTA Office to pick one up. See **Question 90**.

Signing the application

Your *electronic, ink, or verbal signature* is your agreement that the information you provide to DTA is truthful and accurate. When you sign the application, you agree that you understand your rights and responsibilities to follow the rules, including your obligation to report changes when required.

Your right to SNAP benefits back to the day you apply

Don’t delay filling out a SNAP application. If you are approved, you should get SNAP *back to the date* DTA received your *signed* application. [106 C.M.R. §361.080](#). This is the date you applied by phone or online, the date you walked into a local office, or the date DTA electronically

received your SNAP checkbox application from MassHealth (typically the day after you do the MassHealth application).

Cash assistance applications while applying for SNAP

If you are applying for DTA's cash assistance benefits (TAFDC or EAEDC), you can apply for SNAP at the same time. [106 C.M.R. §361.160](#). DTA must still process your SNAP benefits, even if it turns out you are not eligible for cash assistance. [106 C.M.R. §365.120\(A\)\(1\)](#), [\(A\)\(2\)](#).

If you apply for SNAP and you may also be eligible for cash benefits, DTA should ask you if you want to apply for cash. If you do want to apply, the DTA SNAP case worker should connect you to a cash case worker to help you apply for cash benefits. For example, if you have little or no income and are 65 or older or disabled, you might be eligible for EAEDC benefits. You might be eligible for TAFDC if you are pregnant or have children.

Contact MLRI at info@masslegalservices.org if DTA did not start a SNAP application for you on the same day that you applied for cash.

See MLRI's TAFDC and EAEDC Advocacy Guides for more on these cash benefits, available here: [Masslegalservices.org/LegalAdvocacyGuides](https://masslegalservices.org/LegalAdvocacyGuides)

DTA Online Guide: See **Appendix G** for DTA's BEACON 5 Online Guide for this section.

MassHealth SNAP Checkbox Applications: You can find MassHealth online and paper applications that include the SNAP application checkbox here: [Mass.gov/how-to/apply-for-masshealth-the-health-safety-net-or-the-childrens-medical-security-plan](https://mass.gov/how-to/apply-for-masshealth-the-health-safety-net-or-the-childrens-medical-security-plan) See also DTA's instructions for how workers handle MassHealth SNAP applications in the DTA Online Guide, **Appendix G**.

2 What happens after I apply?

Signing a SNAP application is the first step! There are two more steps:

- a phone interview with a DTA worker, **see Question 10** and
- sending proofs (if DTA needs them, **see Question 12**.
- Note: If you would prefer to have your SNAP interview in person, you have a right to have an interview at a DTA office. And if you applied in person, DTA should do your interview the same day. **See Question 10**.

Getting an EBT card

Once DTA verifies your identity, unless you told them in your application you already have a card, DTA should also send you an EBT card and PIN in the U.S. mail. These come in two separate envelopes and can take about 5-7 days to arrive. You can also pick up the EBT card at the local DTA office. See **Question 90** to learn how to get and use your EBT benefits.

To learn more from DTA about EBT cards, visit [Mass.gov/guides/using-your-ebt-card/#-get-a-new-card-](https://www.mass.gov/guides/using-your-ebt-card/#-get-a-new-card-)

DTA Online Guide: See **Appendix G** for links to the DTA's BEACON 5 Online Guide for this section.

3 When am I eligible for expedited (emergency) benefits?

Expedited SNAP benefits are a *faster way* to get your first month of SNAP benefits - *within 7 days* of when you apply if you qualify.

- You may be eligible for *expedited* SNAP if:
- you have \$150 or less in monthly gross income *and* \$100 or less in liquid assets (cash and money in the bank), *or*
- your shelter costs are *higher* than your combined gross monthly income and cash and savings (DTA adds the value of the standard utility allowance to your rent or homeownership costs), *or*
- you are a SNAP-eligible migrant household with \$100 or less in cash and savings.

Expedited SNAP rules: [106 C.M.R. §§365.800-365.850](#).

Example: Stella is 63 and earns \$1,083/month at her part time job. She pays \$500/month rent plus heating costs. Her shelter costs are \$1,414 based on \$500 rent plus the \$914 heating/cooling standard utility allowance. Because her shelter costs are higher than her gross income, Stella is eligible for expedited SNAP.

The SNAP rules require DTA to *screen* all applicants for expedited SNAP when DTA gets your application. [106 C.M.R. §365.800](#). DTA does this screening during the application interview. See **Question 10**. To get *ongoing SNAP* benefits after the expedited month, you will have to provide proofs of all the other eligibility factors. [106 C.M.R. §365.850\(B\)](#).

Important: If you qualify for expedited SNAP, DTA must issue you SNAP benefits and make sure you have an EBT card in hand *within 7 days of when you first apply*.

Troubleshooting:

- **Proofs:** You only need to verify your *identity* to for expedited SNAP. You can provide proof of your identity when you apply. DTA will also verify your identity by confirming your SSN with SSA.
- **Ongoing SNAP:** If you received expedited SNAP, but *did not send DTA all the other required proofs for ongoing SNAP*, DTA should send you a denial notice explaining what documents DTA was missing. If you send DTA these proofs, DTA should reopen your SNAP case.
- **How much:** The amount DTA will give you in expedited SNAP is based on the date you apply and the “cyclical month” of your SNAP application. [106 C.M.R. §365.840](#). You may get more than 1 month of initial benefits, depending on when you apply.

DTA Online Guide: See **Appendix G** for links to the DTA’s BEACON 5 Online Guide for this section.

4 What is Bay State CAP for SSI recipients?

There are two groups of Supplemental Security Income (SSI) recipients who get SNAP benefits through Bay State CAP or the SNAP “Combined Application Project.” [106 C.M.R. §366.910](#). One group are SSI recipients who connect to Bay State CAP through an SSI application or renewal. The second are SSI recipients who were getting SNAP before their SSI began, or who apply for SNAP through DTA.

You may qualify for Bay State CAP SNAP benefits if:

- you are approved for SSI,
- you are 18 or older and not living with a spouse,
- you live alone, or live with others but purchase and prepare your own food separate from the others,
- you do not have regular earned income, and
- a portion of your SSI benefits is federally-funded SSI.

Bay State CAP – applying for SNAP through SSA

In Massachusetts, many SSI applicants and recipients can apply for SNAP directly through the Social Security Administration (SSA) when applying for or renewing SSI.

If you apply through SSA, you *do not need to file* a separate SNAP application at DTA. DTA uses your SSI eligibility information to establish your benefits and send you an EBT card. [106 C.M.R. §366.910\(C\)](#). DTA will use the income and other information they get from SSA, including the amount of your shelter costs. [106 C.M.R. §366.910\(C\)](#) If you are approved, DTA will send you a Bay State CAP approval letter. DTA should also send you an EBT card and PIN. [106 C.M.R. §366.910\(E\)](#).

If you are approved for Bay State CAP through SSA, you may qualify for more in regular SNAP if you have high shelter or medical costs. Tell DTA if you have high rent, homeownership, or health care costs.

You also have a right to switch from Bay State CAP to regular SNAP any time you would get higher SNAP benefits. [106 C.M.R. §366.910 \(H\)\(2\)](#).

The Benefits of Bay State CAP

Bay State Cap SNAP benefits are certified for 36 months. [106 C.M.R. §366.910\(E\)\(3\)](#). During that 36-month period, you are not required to report any changes to DTA. See **Question 99**. However, it is best to tell DTA if you move so you do not miss DTA notices.

When it is time to recertify your benefits, DTA should send you a *short* Bay State CAP Recertification form for you to fill out and send back to DTA.

DTA Online Guide: See **Appendix G** for links to the DTA’s BEACON 5 Online Guide for this section.

SSA Policy Operations Manual: Section SI BOS01801.302; accessed December 29, 2025: <https://secure.ssa.gov/poms.nsf/lnx/0501801302BOS>

5 Can I register to vote when I apply for SNAP?

Yes! Under federal law, SNAP state agencies are required to ask all SNAP and cash assistance household members *who are over age 17 and are U.S. citizens* if they wish to register to vote for any federal elections. Here’s the federal law: [52 U.S. Code § 20506](#).

Massachusetts state law also allows 16- and 17-year-olds to pre-register to vote, [M.G.L. 51 §42](#). Here’s what you should know:

- When you apply, recertify or change your address for your SNAP or cash assistance case, DTA is required to tell you how you can *register* to vote and *assist you* with voter registration. [106 C.M.R. §360.950](#).
- If you apply, recertify or change your address *in person*, DTA is required under federal law to physically hand you a Voter Registration packet. If do this *online or by phone*, DTA is also supposed to mail you a letter with a Voter Registration Form.
- If you complete a Voter Registration Form through DTA, DTA is required to send the completed form to your city/town election office with 5 business days.

IMPORTANT: Voter registration is optional. DTA will not deny or close your SNAP case if you choose not to fill out a Voter Registration Form.

If you have a current MA state ID or driver's license, you can also register to vote online, or get forms mailed to you. Go to the Secretary of State's [Register to Vote webpage](#) for more information on how to register.

Homeless individuals using the voter registration form can use the map on the form to indicate a location for voting purposes if they do not have a “conventional” address.

DTA Online Guide: See **Appendix G** for links to the DTA's BEACON 5 Online Guide for this section.

6 Can someone else help me apply for SNAP?

Yes! You can always ask a family member, friend, or social services agency to help you fill out an application. They can also help you send in proofs, go with you to a local DTA office and/or participate in a phone interview with you - with your permission. See **Question 10** to learn more about the interview.

But *you should sign* the application and *participate* in the interview. That's because *you* are legally responsible for all the information on the application. DTA *must not conduct any SNAP interview* without you! If you are unable to do a SNAP interview due to a disability or impairment, you can appoint an Authorized Representative to handle the application and interview on your behalf. See **Question 7** below.

If the helping friend or agency gives DTA incorrect information – or leaves out information that is important to tell DTA – *you* may end up with a SNAP overpayment, or worse. The helping agency that gave DTA wrong information about your situation could be legally liable as well.

7 What is an Authorized Representative?

An Authorized Representative is someone you choose to act on your behalf and/or manage your SNAP benefits. [106 C.M.R. §§361.300-361.330](#). This is similar to a “representative payee” for SSI or Social Security benefits.

The Authorized Representative does **not** need to have legal guardianship or a court appointment, but you do have to give *your voluntary written consent*.

DTA will ask you to sign a DTA form appointing this person, [Request to Choose Someone to Be My Authorized Representative](#). See **Appendix C**.

You can decide how much control the Authorized Representative has. You can decide if the person you designate as an Authorized Representative can:

- sign the SNAP application on your behalf, receive DTA notices, report changes and talk about your case with DTA, **and/or**
- get a second EBT card to shop for you with your SNAP benefits. DTA can issue two EBT cards – one for you and one for the Authorized Representative.

Troubleshooting:

- **A trusted person:** Be sure to *choose someone you trust*. If this person gives DTA incorrect information and you get too much SNAP, you might have to pay back an overpayment. [106 C.M.R. §§361.310 \(B\)](#).
- **Changing/ending authorized rep status:** DTA *cannot* require you to have an authorized rep if you do not want one. The only exception to this rule is for residents of substance abuse disorder treatment programs and some group home residents. [7 CFR 273.11\(e\) and \(f\)](#), and [106 C.M.R. §§361.350](#)
- You can also ask DTA to *remove the person* who is your Authorized Rep from your SNAP case any time. For example, you may find a family member or friend is not spending your SNAP benefits appropriately.
- **More info:** To learn about the difference between a helping agency and an Authorized Representative, see [MLRI FAQ: Masslegalservices.org/content/helping-agency-vs-authorized-representative](#).

DTA Online Guide: See **Appendix G** for links to the DTA’s BEACON 5 Online Guide for this section.

8 Can I give someone permission to talk with DTA about my SNAP case?

You have the right to give permission to anyone you trust to help you find out what's going on with your SNAP case. This can be a social service agency, food pantry, legal services, a trusted family member or friend. This is *different* from appointing an *authorized representative*. See **Question 7**. You can also call the DTA Assistance Line with an agency or friend on the line at the same time to help you do a “3-way” call.

Before anyone can talk with DTA about your case (if you are not with them by phone or in person), you need to send DTA a *written and signed statement* that allows DTA to share information with the person or organization helping you. [106 C.M.R. §360.400](#).

Appendix C has a sample *Client Consent Allowing DTA to Release Information to a Helping Agency*. You can also send DTA a handwritten or typed note (signed and dated) with the same information. There is no specific DTA form that must be used.

DTA Online Guide: See **Appendix G** for links to the DTA's BEACON 5 Online Guide for this section.

9 How do I apply if I live in a group home, substance abuse center, or teen program?

Group home residents

If you live in a *licensed group home* for persons with disabilities, you may be eligible for SNAP benefits as a one-person household even if you share common meals at the group home. [106 C.M.R. §361.240\(B\)](#). A licensed group home is licensed by the state as a community-based residential facility that has no more than 16 residents living there at a time. [106 C.M.R. §365.620](#).

Some group homes act as the *Authorized Representative* for residents. That is common for group homes run by the Mass Department of Developmental Services (DDS) and some group homes run by Mass Department of Mental Health (DMH). This means a group home manager may file a SNAP application and/or receive the EBT card for the resident.

Other group homes that are more “transitional” or short term may have residents apply for SNAP and buy and prepare their own food. Some group homes have point of sale (POS) devices that allow them to collect the EBT benefits from SNAP residents for common food.

If you have filed a SNAP application yourself - or are already getting SNAP when you join the group home - the group home should let you manage your own SNAP benefits. Under the SNAP

rules, the group home can only take over your benefits if they make *an individual determination* that you cannot handle your own affairs. If the group home determines that you do not have the physical or mental ability to handle your own affairs, the group home will file an application for SNAP on your behalf and may control your EBT card (act as an “Authorized Representative” to do your SNAP application). You can challenge this determination.

If you apply for your own SNAP, you can choose whether to have the group home transact (keep) your EBT card to buy food or if you want to keep your own EBT card to make and buy your own food. See [7 C.F.R. 273.11\(f\)](#).

Residents of substance abuse disorder treatment centers

If you are a resident of a *licensed substance abuse disorder treatment program*, the SNAP rules say that the treatment program must be your Authorized Representative. [106 C.M.R. §365.610](#). Even if you apply for SNAP on your own, you must transfer your SNAP benefits to the treatment program for food purchases while you are staying there.

“*Sober houses*” typically provide room and meals for adults transitioning from a treatment program and/or referred by a court or probation officer. Sober houses may be regulated at the local level but usually are not licensed or regulated by the Massachusetts Department of Public Health (DPH). If you live in a “sober house” or other roomer/board situation not licensed by DPH, the sober house cannot take your EBT card unless you *voluntarily* appoint them as your Authorized Representative to transact SNAP on your behalf. Contact Legal Services if this happens.

Note: Drug and alcohol treatment centers and group homes are responsible for any SNAP overpayments that happen while the person getting SNAP is a resident of the treatment center or group home. [106 C.M.R. §365.650](#). The only exception is if a group home resident applied for SNAP on their own, then the resident is responsible for any over-issuance. [7 C.F.R. 273.11\(f\)\(7\)](#).

Residents of teen living programs

If you are living in a *teen parent program*, the program is given the authority to decide if it will be the authorized representative and receive the SNAP benefits, or if it will allow you to apply for and spend the benefits yourself. [106 C.M.R. §365.620\(B\)](#).

When leaving a residential program

After you leave a group home or treatment center, the program *must return your EBT card to you*. If you do not have an EBT card in your name, they should help you get one. When you leave, the group home or treatment center must give you back SNAP benefits in the following ways:

- If they have not yet used any of your SNAP for the month, they must return your entire monthly allotment.
- If they have already used some of your SNAP for the month but you leave *before* the 16th

of the month, the program must give you back half of your allotment. If you leave *after* the 16th and the program has already used your SNAP for that month, you may not get any SNAP back.

For the rules on how your EBT benefits should be restored to you, see [7 C.F.R. 273.11\(e\)\(6\) and \(f\)\(6\)](#). Contact the DTA Ombuds or your local Legal Services if you do not get back your EBT card or a portion of your benefits. See **Question 31**.

DTA Online Guide: See **Appendix G** for links to the DTA’s BEACON 5 Online Guide for this section.

10 Does DTA have to interview me?

YES. DTA must interview all applicants for SNAP benefits. [106 C.M.R. §361.500](#). The interview must be done by a DTA SNAP worker. Conversations with SNAP Outreach partner are not SNAP interviews.

DTA usually does the interview over the phone.

- After you apply, DTA is supposed to make two “cold calls” to reach you for an interview. If they do not reach you, DTA should leave a voice message, and then call back again. If DTA cannot reach you a second time, they will schedule an interview appointment.
- DTA should schedule the interview within 7 days from the date you applied. DTA will mail you a notice and send text messages about the date and time they will call for the interview. You can also check DTACConnect to see the date and time of the appointment.
- In *advance* of your scheduled interview, you can request a different interview date and time on through DTACConnect. See **Question 23**.
- On the date and time of your scheduled interview, DTA will call you with an automated phone system. For some phones, the caller ID may say “COMM of MASS” or 877-382-2363 (this depends on your cell phone provider).
 - When you pick up the call, you will hear an automated message asking you to press a specific number if you want to talk to a DTA worker. You may need to *wait for a few minutes* for the worker to come on the line. If you need to wait for more than a couple of minutes, let MLRI know at info@masslegalservices.org.
- If you do not pick up, DTA should leave you a voicemail and call again. If you do not get the call from DTA, double check that DTA has your correct phone number – this is the phone number listed on your interview appointment notice and you DTACConnect account. You can update your phone number on DTACConnect whenever it changes.

- You do not need to wait for the scheduled interview. A couple days after you apply, you can call the DTA Assistance Line for any time during business hours: 877-382-2363. Make sure to provide your SSN, your DTA Agency ID, or your EBT card number and year of birth so the computer system knows who you are. This ensures you can reach a worker during times of high call volume.

In-person interviews at a DTA office

If you want one, you also have the right to go to a local DTA office for an *in-person* interview. [106 C.M.R. §§361.550](#).

- You can go any time during business hours to a local DTA office to apply in person and/or get an interview the same day.
- If you do not list a phone number on your application, DTA should schedule you for an in-person interview. You can always use someone else's phone (a friend or social services agency) if you prefer a phone interview.
- When you do an in-person interview, DTA should offer you a private room where you can speak to a worker. DTA should never do the interview in any area where others can hear you.
- If DTA denies you an in-person interview, contact your local Legal Services or MLRI at info@masslegalservices.org.

If you miss the interview call

If you miss the scheduled interview, DTA is *required* to send you a *written notice* called a “Notice of Missed Interview” (a “NOMI”). The DTA notice must say that you have the right to another interview. [106 C.M.R. §§361.500, 361.700\(B\)\(1\)](#). If you reach a DTA worker by phone or go in-person, you should not be turned away and told to wait for a rescheduled interview.

DTA will deny your SNAP application if you do not have an interview *within 30 days* of when you applied, and you did not try to reach DTA for the interview. [106 C.M.R. §361.700\(B\)\(1\)](#). You have the right to reapply for benefits. The denied application will not be held against you, but the start date of your benefits will be the date you re-apply for SNAP.

DTA *cannot deny your SNAP application or make you reapply* if DTA failed to contact you, failed to connect your call with a live worker when they called you, failed to send you a notice about your scheduled interview, or failed to send a NOMI. You have a right to call the DTA Assistance Line and ask to speak with a supervisor, or you can call the DTA Ombudsman office. You can also file an appeal.

If you tried to reach DTA without success, DTA cannot deny your SNAP application unless you actually “refused to cooperate” with the SNAP interview. An example of a refusal to cooperate is where you tell DTA that you will simply not do an interview. [106 CMR §361.400](#). However, if you missed DTA's calls and you tried to call them back – even if you could not reach them - that

is not a refusal to cooperate. Contact the DTA Ombuds office and/or file an appeal to get back benefits. It helps if you can save screen shots of your calls to DTA showing you tried. **Appendix C** has a fact sheet that walks you through the steps you can take to get back benefits.

DTA Online Guide: See **Appendix G** for links to the DTA's BEACON 5 Online Guide for this section.

11 What happens during the interview?

During the interview, the DTA worker should do at least these 8 things:

1. Screen you for expedited (emergency) benefits. See **Question 3**.
2. Confirm your eligibility information. This includes DTA confirming information they get from other government databases, information you gave in your application, and who you must be part of your SNAP household. See **Question 34**.
3. Review documents you sent in and tell you *what* verifications DTA needs and *when* they are due. See **Question 12**.
4. Answer any questions and *offer to help* if you need help getting proofs or contacting a third party for information.
5. Review the *exemptions and the work rules* if you or a household member is subject to the ABAWD 3-month time limit. See Questions 60-65.
6. Tell you *how long* your benefits are certified for, *what changes* you need to report to DTA, and *when* you need to send back an Interim Report and/or a Recertification form. See **Question 99**.
7. Explain *your rights and responsibilities*, as well as the *penalties* for committing fraud or for other program rules.
8. Issue you an *EBT card* if you need one and tell you how to use it.

SNAP interview rules: [106 C.M.R. §§361.500 - 361-550](#).

DTA Online Guide: See **Appendix G** for links to the DTA's BEACON 5 Online Guide for this section.

12 What proofs does DTA need and when?

During the interview, the DTA worker should *verbally tell you* what proofs are required and ask if you need their help getting them. [106 C.M.R. § 361.550](#). DTA should also send you a *verification checklist* (often called a “VC-1”) with *at least 10 days* for you to get them mandatory proofs.

How much time you have to send DTA proofs

You have a *full 30 days* from the day you apply to get in your proofs.

If you had an interview but some proofs are still missing by Day 30, DTA will send you a “pending denial notice.” [106 C.M.R. §361.930](#). This means you have *another 30 days* to get them missing proofs and not have to reapply. See **Question 21**.

DTA *cannot limit proofs to any single document*. Any document that proves an eligibility factor should be accepted. [106 C.M.R. §§361.640\(A\), 361.650](#). If you have trouble getting DTA proofs, *ask DTA for help!*

If you got SNAP or cash benefits *in the past and are re-applying*, DTA should not ask for permanent verifications you already gave them, such as proof of your age or your identity.

Mandatory proofs

The SNAP rules require that you provide proof of certain *mandatory eligibility factors* to qualify for SNAP benefits. [106 C.M.R. §361.610](#). This includes proof of:

- the identity of the head of household (the person who applies and whose name is on the EBT card and on DTA notices),
- your Massachusetts residence,
- the Social Security Numbers (SSNs) for all household members who are applying (no need to send DTA the SSN cards),
- current earned income, or self-employment and your business expenses,
- unearned income that DTA cannot verify through a database,
- the last day of work, if you stopped work recently,
- immigration status if you or a household member is applying for SNAP but is not a U.S. citizen, and
- other proofs that DTA needs to be sure you are eligible.

DTA will also ask for information about allowable income deductions including your shelter

costs, utilities, dependent care and, for some households, health care expenses. This information is *optional* – which means the information is not required to approve your SNAP case, but you may get less SNAP benefits (or on some cases, \$0). See **Questions 13 and 14**.

Troubleshooting:

- **Missing wages:** If you have trouble producing missing wage information or your last day of work, DTA can do a “collateral contact” and contact the employer directly for proof. If there is a missing pay stub, DTA should be able to figure out the missing week of income from other pay stubs.
- **Terminated income:** DTA should only ask for proof that income has ended in limited situations. Contact Legal Services if you are asked for this proof but you can’t get it.
- **A new baby:** Do not wait until you have an SSN for the baby. DTA should add the baby to your DTA case without needing an SSN until your next recertification or for 6 months after birth (whichever is later).

DTA Online Guide: See **Appendix G** for links to the DTA’s BEACON 5 Online Guide for this section.

13 What information can I self-declare?

You can self-declare certain information. DTA should accept your self-declaration unless DTA determines the information is *questionable*. See **Question 17** defining what is “questionable.” This includes:

- Your household composition – for example, if you live with others who (not required to be in your household) and you purchase and prepare most of your food separately from them.
- The U.S. citizenship of any household member.
- Your date of birth.
- Your college student status.
- Certain exemptions from the ABAWD Work Rules. See **Questions 60-65**.

See list of SNAP verifications at application: [106 C.M.R. § 361.610](#).

You can *verbally tell DTA this information* when you talk with a SNAP worker, or write down it on your SNAP Application, Recertification or Interim Report forms. You can also send DTA a written statement that you sign and date.

Many allowable expenses must now be verified, unless you tell DTA verbally or in writing that you cannot get proof, and why. This includes:

- Shelter expenses. See **Question 85**.
- Utility expenses. See **Question 84**.
- Childcare or adult dependent care expenses. See **Question 83**.
- If you are age 60 or older or get a disability-based benefit, certain out-of-pocket medical expenses. See **Question 80**.

DTA Online Guide: See **Appendix G** for links to the DTA’s BEACON 5 Online Guide for this section.

14 What proofs are optional?

To calculate the correct amount of your monthly SNAP benefits, DTA needs information about certain household expenses, in addition to proof of your income.

Expense information
Shelter costs (rent, homeownership) and utilities
Child or adult dependent care costs
Health care costs (for household members 60 or older or receiving a disability benefit)
Child support paid to child outside home
Business expenses (self-employment)

This information is *optional*. That means if you do not provide it to DTA, DTA *cannot deny* your application for missing verifications – but your SNAP benefits will be calculated without these deductions. In some cases, like with child support paid or business expenses, your application may be denied without verifying those costs, if you would be over income without them. [106 C.M.R. § 364.450\(B\)](#).

DTA will ask you for proof of these expenses. However, if you cannot provide verification, you need to affirmatively tell DTA that you cannot provide it and why.

For example: Jane is staying with her cousin Sarah. She pays \$500/month to Sarah plus half of Sarah’s utility bills. Sarah’s landlord does not know Jane is living with her. Sarah will not put anything in writing because she is

afraid her landlord will evict her. Jane can self-declare that she pays \$500 per month in rent and is unable to provide any third-party proof. DTA should accept Jane's self-declaration.

Troubleshooting:

- **Child support:** As long as you verify your obligation to pay child support and the amount you pay, the child support should be excluded from your gross income and net income. If you do not verify your child support obligation and amount - and your gross income exceeds the gross income test - you will be denied SNAP. Double check DTA's SNAP math if you are denied SNAP or your SNAP benefits are too low. See **Question 82**.
- **Self-employment:** DTA should only count pre-tax net income if you report self-employment income. Be sure to track and report to DTA your business expenses, including if you are a gig worker. Send DTA your Schedule C if filed, or a Profit/Loss statement. Ask DTA for help identifying and verifying your business expenses. Double check DTA's math if you are denied SNAP or your SNAP benefits are too low. See **Question 73**.

15 How do I send DTA my documents?

You can send documents to DTA many ways. [106 C.M.R. §361.650](#).

1. **Take a photo and upload your documents** through DTACONnect. The documents go straight into your DTA case record. This is the *fastest way* to get DTA proofs! See **Question 23**.
2. **Fax** documents to DTA at **617-887-8765**.
3. **Mail** documents to: Department of Transitional Assistance (DTA)
P.O. Box 4406, Taunton, MA 02780-0420.
4. **Hand-deliver** documents to any local DTA office in person. DTA should help you scan them directly into your case and give you back your original documents.

Troubleshooting:

- **Urgent action:** If you need DTA to take quick action on your case and you are at a local DTA office, ask to speak with a DTA worker or manager who can look at the documents. If you need urgent help at a DTA office during business hours and do not get it, contact the DTA ombuds office (see **Question 31**) and MLRI at info@masslegalservices.org.
- **Tracking your documents:** It's best to upload your documents directly to your

DTAConnect account. *If you mail or fax documents to DTA*, keep track of the date and proof that you sent DTA the documents in case documents get lost. If you mail or fax documents, write *on each page* of the documents your name and your DTA “Agency ID” (if you know it) or the last 4 digits of your SSN.

DTA Online Guide: See **Appendix G** for links to the DTA’s BEACON 5 Online Guide for this section.

16 Should DTA help me if I am having a hard time getting proofs?

YES! DTA workers are required to help you get proofs if you tell DTA you are having difficulty. [106 C.M.R. §361.650](#). This includes offering to do a “collateral contact” – a call to a third party – to confirm information in your case. [106 C.M.R. §361.640\(B\)](#).

For example, a DTA worker can:

- Contact an employer for missing wage information.
- Contact another state to confirm the date your SNAP case in that state closed.

If you need DTA to contact a third party for information, give DTA the third party’s contact information and your permission for DTA to contact them. If you need DTA to make a collateral contact and a worker tells you they can’t do one, ask to speak with a supervisor.

However, DTA *cannot require you* to agree to a third-party contact if you can verify the information they need some other way. Your privacy is important and must be respected. [106 C.M.R. §360.400](#).

If you and DTA cannot get the proofs they need, DTA must accept the *best available evidence* for verifying income. This may end up being your self-declaration. See [106 C.M.R. §363.210\(G\)\(3\)](#). For example, DTA should accept a self-declaration if:

- Your former employer refuses to give you proof about your pay and will not talk with DTA.
- You are self-employed but you do not have detailed business records and make so little you do not file taxes.
- You are paid in cash and have no other records of your income.

If you have a disability that makes it hard for you to get proofs or comply with other DTA rules, see **Question 28**.

DTA Online Guide: See **Appendix G** for links to the DTA’s BEACON 5 Online Guide for this section.

17 What if DTA does not accept the proofs I sent them?

DTA should accept *any documents* that reasonably prove your eligibility, unless the information is *questionable*. [106 C.M.R. § 361.640](#). DTA must review the individual circumstances of each household before determining whether information is questionable. “Questionable” means the information you gave DTA is *inconsistent* with information you already shared with them or information they know about (e.g. through database checks). [106 C.M.R. § 361.620](#).

Example: Sandy applied for SNAP. DTA does a Registry of Motor Vehicles (RMV) check that shows that her ex-husband still registers his car at her address. During her interview she explained that she divorced her husband six months ago and he does not live with her. This information is not questionable and does not contradict what she said during her interview. Sandy has no control over her ex-husband and does not own the car. Sandy should not be required to prove where her ex lives.

Example: Carl reports paying \$2,500 per month in rent, but he currently earns only \$2,000 net per month. Carl explains his roommate who shared costs recently moved out, and he is now behind in his rent. This is not questionable.

Troubleshooting:

- **Cooperation from third parties:** If income verification depends on the cooperation of a *third party* – such as getting wage information from an employer – DTA should accept your self-declaration if the employer will not cooperate. This is the “best evidence available” rule under [106 CMR 361.610\(A\)](#). DTA should also offer assistance if you are having trouble getting a document from any other third party. See **Question 16**.
- **DTA rejects proofs:** If DTA does not accept the proofs you give them, the DTA worker must record the reason for rejecting your proofs in your SNAP case – in the “case narrative” notes. [106 C.M.R. § 361.660](#). You have the right to ask for a copy of the notes, to challenge the worker’s decision, including going to a supervisor or the Ombuds, or to file an appeal.
- **Proofs you cannot get:** If DTA asks you to prove something that you cannot provide or DTA fails to offer you help, you can speak with a supervisor, call the Ombuds Office, or file an appeal.

18 What if DTA questions my income or my living expenses?

Many low-income households have living costs that exceed their income. Households often borrow from family members or friends, run up credit cards, or have unpaid bills that lead to a utility shut off or eviction. None of this is fraudulent activity; it is how most households survive tough times.

If DTA thinks your income is too low to meet your rent or other costs when you apply for SNAP, a DTA worker may call and ask you questions about how you are getting by. DTA may refer to this inquiry as “suspected of living above means” or “SLAM.” *If you are asked about your income and expenses, it is very important that you answer DTA’s questions truthfully.*

These are common situations that DTA should not consider questionable:

- If you *borrow money* from friends or relatives or borrow against your credit card to pay your expenses, that is not questionable. Loans are not countable income. See **Question 69**.
- *Cash contributions* towards part of a specific living expense from people who are *not legally obligated* to support you are not questionable. In most cases, these payments should also not count as income in your case. Examples of non-legally responsible people include a grandparent, aunt, uncle, neighbor, or friend who is just helping you out. See **Question 70**.

However, if you get *cash contributions (money)* from people who are *legally responsible* for your living expenses, such as child support for your children or alimony from a spouse, that is countable income.

DTA should not require proofs *unless* the information you provide is deemed “questionable.” See **Question 17**. However, if your shelter costs or other expenses continue to exceed your income at the point of your SNAP *recertification*, DTA will likely ask you for more proof. That can include documents that show you are behind in your rent or utilities, or a statement from people you are borrowing money from.

DTA Online Guide: See **Appendix G** for links to the DTA’s BEACON 5 Online Guide for this section.

19 If I move, how do I report my new address?

It’s important to tell DTA if your mailing address changes so you don’t miss important notices. Also, if you move and your shelter costs go up you may be eligible for more SNAP. Whenever

you tell DTA about a change of address, DTA should update your address in your case record.

To report a mailing address change

- Update your mailing address on DTACConnect.
- Call the DTA Assistance Line at 877-382-2363 and follow the prompts to report a change through the automated phone system (you may be told you need to reach a worker).
- Go to a local DTA office or mail or fax DTA your new mailing address.

If you move before your next SNAP recertification or interim report

When you report a move to DTA, you have a choice about whether you report a change for both where you get mail (your mailing address) and where you live (your residential address). If you only get SNAP from DTA (not SNAP plus EAEDC or TAFDC), you can choose to report just the change in your *mailing address*. If you do this, you don't need to provide proof of your new rent/housing and utility costs *until* your next Interim Report or Recertification.

If you tell DTA your *residential* address has changed, DTA will require you to verify your updated rent/housing and utility costs. If you don't verify them, DTA will remove those costs from your case. This may cause your SNAP to go down.

If you get DTA cash benefits and SNAP, you must report a change in your residential address and your shelter costs to DTA within 10 days of when you move. See **Question 99**.

If DTA gets returned mail:

DTA mail is not forwarded by the U.S. Post Office. If you move and DTA does not have your new address, DTA letters will likely get returned to DTA. However, if you left a forwarding address with the U.S. Post office, DTA may use that information to update your address. It is important to always tell DTA if you have a new mailing address.

DTA may also close your cash case if they get returned mail for you, and/or if you move but do not respond to DTA letters asking you to verify your new address. This may not be correct. If DTA closes your DTA benefits due to returned mail, contact MLRI at info@masslegalservices.org.

DTA Online Guide: See **Appendix G** for links to the DTA's BEACON 5 Online Guide for this section.

20 Can I get my SNAP case reopened if I am denied for lack of proofs?

DTA must give you a full 30 days from the date you applied to get in proofs before your SNAP application is denied. They must send you a notice in advance of the proofs needed and options for proofs.

If the proofs DTA needs are still missing by day 30, DTA will send you a “*pending denial notice*.” [106 C.M.R. §361.930](#). The SNAP pending denial notice should both list the specific proofs (verifications) that are still missing **and** give you *another 30 days to bring in these proofs*. This is also the policy if you got expedited (emergency) SNAP.

If you get the proofs to DTA within this second 30-day period, your case should get *reopened*. You do not need to reapply. [106 C.M.R. §361.940](#). However, your benefits may be prorated. See **Question 21**.

Example: Carol applied for SNAP on June 1. She sent DTA most of the required proofs by June 29th but was missing wage stubs from one of her part-time jobs. She was sent a denial notice dated June 30th telling her she was denied and listed the proofs missing (wage stubs from her part-time job). Carol sends DTA the missing wage stubs on July 10. DTA should reopen her SNAP application without making her reapply.

DTA Online Guide: See **Appendix G** for links to the DTA’s BEACON 5 Online Guide for this section.

21 What if DTA does not give me SNAP back to the date I applied (“pro-rating”)?

If DTA denies your SNAP benefits for missing proofs, you still have options. If you send DTA the missing proofs *within 30 days* of the denial, DTA should reopen your SNAP application. You do **not** need to reapply.

But DTA may only give you benefits starting with *the date DTA received the required proofs*, not the date you applied for SNAP. This is called “*pro-rating*” your SNAP benefits. This means you may end up with less SNAP benefits for the first month.

These pro-ration rules may also apply when you get DTA proof of your shelter and/or dependent care costs late. 7 CFR 273.2(f)(3)(ii). See **Question 13** about the self-declaration policy.

If the delay is your fault, DTA will start your benefits *the date they got the proofs*.

Example: Louise applied for SNAP on June 1st but was distracted with a new job and changes with her child’s daycare. She did not send in her pay stubs. DTA sends her a “pending denial” notice on June 30th. Louise sends

DTA her paystubs on July 10th. DTA approves her case, but only gave her SNAP starting July 10th. She missed \$300 in retroactive SNAP as a result.

If the delay is DTA's fault, your SNAP benefits should **not be "pro-rated."** [106 C.M.R. §§361.910-361.920](#) *A delay is **not** your fault if:*

- DTA did not tell you which proofs they needed or what alternate proofs they can accept,
- You sent DTA proofs but they did not look at them,
- DTA did not tell you that the proofs you sent them were not adequate,
- DTA did not give you enough time to get in proofs, **or**
- DTA did not offer help if you had trouble getting the proofs.

Example: In the above case, you learn that Louise did not have copies of her paystubs because her employer refused to give her a copy. You also learn that when Louise told DTA this, but the DTA worker did not offer to contact the employer. Louise ended up having to schedule a meeting with her employer's HR office - over an hour from her home - to get a copy of her paystubs. She got the paystubs to DTA on July 10th. In this situation, the delay in getting DTA the earnings proof was not her fault. DTA should not pro-rate her SNAP. She should get \$300 more to cover June 1 to July 9.

How to find out if my benefits were prorated

DTA's eligibility computer system (BEACON) is automatically programmed to decide whether the delay was DTA or the applicant's fault - *without* diving into all the facts. This "automated" decision may be incorrect, especially if the DTA worker failed to offer help.

- To figure out if your SNAP was "pro-rated," check the SNAP amount DTA deposited on your card after your application was approved. You can also see this information on DTACONnect.
- If the amount of SNAP benefits DTA gave you doesn't start from the date you applied, it may have been pro-rated.
- If you think DTA was wrong in pro-rating your benefits, ask DTA *how* they determined "fault." If you disagree with the worker's explanation, you can talk to a Supervisor, the DTA Ombuds Office, or file an appeal.
- If you were denied or terminated from SNAP within the last 90 days for missing proofs, you have a right to appeal. The hearing officer should accept proofs you provide at the hearing under special "de novo" appeal rules and should consider whether DTA was at fault for not doing its job. See **Question 109**. Note, you should also reapply for benefits (to get back on quickly) even if you file an appeal for retroactive benefits.

DTA Online Guide: See **Appendix G** for links to the DTA’s BEACON 5 Online Guide for this section.

22 How do I get information about my SNAP by phone?

Call the **DTA Assistance Line at 1-877-382-2363** to hear automated information about your case. After you select your language, press 1 to enter your identifying information. You have a choice to enter your SSN, EBT card number, or your DTA Agency ID (found on all DTA notices), plus your year of birth.

After you identify yourself through the DTA Assistance Line, you can get information on the amount of your EBT benefits, when your case will be reviewed, change your phone number and more! Check DTA’s webpage, [How to Contact DTA by Phone](#), here to find out what information is available through the DTA Assistance Line.

Note: If you are worried about an abusive partner or unauthorized callers trying to get your personal information, you can ask DTA about a “block” on this service. See **Question 32**.

To speak with a DTA SNAP worker

Call Monday through Friday from 8:15 AM to 4:45 PM and follow the prompts to reach a case manager. Provide your Social Security Number, Agency ID, or EBT card number and year of birth to make sure the computer system can find your case and prioritize your call if DTA needs to speak with you.

If you reach a worker, be sure to ask the worker for their name and write it down.

If you are calling because *you need an interview*, the DTA worker should do an interview on the spot and not tell you to call back later.

If you call and hear the “high call volume” message and the phone call ends, you have rights! See [MLRI’s tip sheet](#) how to get help if you can’t get through the DTA Assistance Line.

You can reach other staff on the Assistance Line, including:

- DTA local office staff if you want to apply for cash (TAFDC or EAEDC)
- Domestic Violence specialists (see **Question 32**).
- Client Assistance Coordinator for a disability accommodation (see **Question 28**).

- Staff to learn about education/training programs

Troubleshooting:

- **If you do not have an active or pending case:** If you are not applying, not on SNAP, and have not applied or been on in the past 90 days, you will not be able to get through by entering your SSN, Agency ID, or EBT card number. In this situation, to reach a worker press 7 when you call (the option for other languages). See above if you cannot get through.
- **Helping agencies:** If you are calling on behalf of a client, be sure to send DTA a signed client consent in advance.
- **Limited cell phone minutes:** If you are worried about limited cell minutes, ask for a call back or try to use a landline or the phone of a social service agency line or friend with unlimited minutes.

DTA Online Guide: See **Appendix G** for links to the DTA's BEACON 5 Online Guide for this section.

23 How do I get information about my SNAP case or report changes online or with my smartphone?

You can use DTA Connect to share updates with DTA, upload documents, fill out Recertification or Interim Report forms, view notices DTA sends you, lock and unlock your EBT card, and see important information about your case.

You can also use DTACONnect to tell DTA about changes to rent, child or dependent care costs, medical expenses, and more.

To set up a DTACONnect account you need an email address. To learn how to set up an account and see a list of what you can do, see [DTA's "Help Using DTACONnect" page](#).

You may need speak with a DTA worker before you can access your DTA account information once you create an account. And, you won't be able to see case information if your case was closed more than 90 days ago.

DTA provides two options:

- **DTACONnect** is the *mobile app* for DTA clients. It is free and can be downloaded for iPhones at the App store or for Androids on Google play.

- **DTAConnect.com** is a free *online portal* for DTA clients.

DTA Online Guide: See **Appendix G** for links to the DTA’s BEACON 5 Online Guide for this section.

24 Does DTA send text messages or emails?

Yes! In addition to paper notices and information posted on DTAConnect, DTA reaches out to households at certain points via text and/or email with status updates and information on DTA benefits. For example, DTA texts/emails when DTA:

- receives your application
- schedules an interview, or you miss your interview
- is missing proofs
- when they get documents
- approves, denies or closes your SNAP case
- sends you an EBT card
- approves your Interim Report/Recertification

The text messages DTA sends will show up from “382 674.”

You can opt out by replying “opt out” to the text message. Some texts are sent in English, Spanish, Portuguese, Chinese, Haitian Creole, and Vietnamese. *You can also update your phone number* or add an email address on DTAConnect.

IMPORTANT REMINDER: Never provide your personal information, EBT card number, or Personal Identification Number (PIN) to unidentified callers, or to a link provided via text or email. DTA will never ask for your PIN. Learn more at [Mass.gov/ProtectYourEBT](https://www.mass.gov/ProtectYourEBT).

25 What is the Senior Assistance Office?

The Senior Assistance Office (SAO) is a special DTA office designed for customers age 60 and

over to answer questions and process SNAP cases. They also take SNAP applications by phone. You can reach them directly by phone without entering any information.

If you are age 60 or older and you apply for SNAP, the SAO will do your phone interview, answer your questions and process your SNAP case. If there is a wait time, DTA will give you the option of leaving a message to get a call back from an SAO worker.

Senior Assistance Office Phone: (833) 712-8027

26 What if I do not speak English?

If English is not your primary language, DTA must provide you with a bilingual DTA worker or communicate through an interpreter service.

When calling the **DTA Assistance Line**, DTA has a recording with the prompts you can push to get service in your language. The Assistance Line is recorded in English, Spanish, Portuguese, Cantonese, Vietnamese, and Haitian Creole. It prompts callers who speak another language to press 7 to reach a worker. See **Question 22** if you can't get through the Assistance Line.

If you select a language other than English, then:

- You should be connected to a bilingual DTA worker,
- The DTA worker should add a bilingual DTA interpreter to do a three-way call with you, or
- The DTA worker should use their language line interpreter service.

Under federal law, DTA must provide you with an interpreter if you need one. DTA should not tell you to bring your own interpreter or have a family member interpret for you. See [Title VI of the Civil Rights Act of 1964, 42 U.S.C. § 2000d](#).

DTA's Language Access Materials and Resources:

- **DTA Online applications** at DTAConnect.com, most **notices**, and the **Interim Report and Recertification** are in English, Spanish, Portuguese, Haitian Creole, Cantonese, and Vietnamese.
- **DTA paper applications** are available in 13 languages: Spanish, Portuguese, French, Haitian Creole, Chinese, Vietnamese, Khmer, Korean, Russian, Italian, Polish, Arabic and English. You can download and print these applications from DTA's [Helpful Forms and Documents](#) page.
- **DTAConnect and languages:** The “preferred language” question on the DTAConnect.com online application currently defaults to English, even for

applications filed in languages other than English. As of the writing of this Guide, DTAConnect does not record the language of the application if it is in a different language than the “preferred language” question answer. For example, if a person submits the application in Portuguese but forgets to answer the preferred language question, DTA will think the applicant speaks English and will have no idea they speak Portuguese. Contact MLRI at info@masslegalservices.org if DTA contacts an LEP applicant in English.

DTA Online Guide: See **Appendix G** for links to the DTA’s BEACON 5 Online Guide for this section.

27 What if I am deaf or hard of hearing?

If you are deaf or hard of hearing, DTA must ensure effective communication with you. [106 C.M.R. §360.510](#). This can include if you need interpretation, communication access real time translation (CART), or sign language interpretation to communicate with your case manager.

- DTA requires staff to be trained on and use auxiliary aids. All DTA local offices now have Video Remote Interpreting (VRI) services.
- VRI is an auxiliary aid to communicate with Deaf and hard of hearing individuals using remote American Sign Language (ASL) interpreter services. If you are Deaf or hard of hearing and would like ASL interpreter service through VRI, go to an office with VRI or contact a Client Assistance Coordinator to set up an appointment in advance.
- DTA also has an option to communicate with a Client Assistance Coordinator via Zoom, with an ASL interpreter on the Zoom video.

For a list of DTA’s Client Assistance Coordinators (CACs) available in each local office, go DTA’s webpage [Help for Applicants & Clients with Disabilities](#).

DTA Online Guide: See **Appendix G** for links to the DTA’s BEACON 5 Online Guide for this section.

28 What if a disability makes it hard for me to apply or comply with DTA rules?

The federal Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA) requires DTA to provide equal access to

programs and services to qualified people with disabilities. [42 U.S.C. § 12132](#); see [106 C.M.R. §§360.250, 701.390](#).

Under the ADA you are a person with a qualifying disability if you have a disability that substantially impairs a major life activity, such as learning, understanding, walking, working, breathing, or caring for yourself.

Disabilities include physical or mental health impairments, and intellectual disabilities. A temporary health problem like a broken leg may not be a disability under the ADA.

You can be disabled under the ADA even if you are not receiving any benefits on the basis of disability and even if DTA has decided you do not qualify for an exemption because of disability.

If a disability makes it hard for you to do the things DTA asks you to do to get and keep your benefits, you can ask DTA for a **reasonable accommodation**. An accommodation may be appropriate if your disability makes it hard for you to:

- Understand DTA's notices and forms
- Give DTA the verifications it asks for
- Communicate with DTA
- Get to the DTA office
- Meet deadlines or a specific rule or requirement

DTA must tailor the accommodation to what you need because of disability. Examples of accommodations can include DTA:

- Helping you understand notices and complete forms
- Giving you extra help to meet a rule
- Giving you extra time to meet a deadline
- Changing a requirement or rule
- Naming someone to get copies of mail DTA sends you, or to talk to DTA on your behalf (See **Question 7** on choosing to appoint an Authorized Representative)
- Providing an auxiliary aid (such as an ASL interpreter or large print notices)

Example 1: Because of your learning disability, you need help understanding DTA notices and help completing the paperwork that DTA asks you to complete. DTA should accommodate you by explaining notices to you and by filling out the forms with you instead of requiring you to fill forms out by yourself.

Example 2: You have a hearing, vision, or other condition that makes it hard for you to communicate. DTA should ask you what kind of help you prefer to communicate with DTA. This help is usually called an auxiliary aid. DTA should try to provide your preferred auxiliary aid or work with you to find an acceptable alternative.

Example 3: Because of your disability, you have a hard time communicating with third parties. You need DTA to contact your health care provider to complete the special ABAWD Medical Report.

Troubleshooting:

- **When to request an accommodation:** An accommodation can be requested at any time, including after DTA has issued a notice stopping or lowering your benefits.
- **Scope of accommodations:** DTA cannot require you to accept a specific accommodation (such as requiring a helper or authorized representative to act for the client). Instead, DTA should work with you to find an accommodation that you agree to.
- **Limits to accommodations:** DTA is not required to provide an accommodation that fundamentally alters its program rules. For example, DTA cannot count medical expenses for someone who has disabilities but is not 60 or older or receiving a disability-based benefit.
- **Advocacy:** Contact a Legal Services advocate if you think DTA should provide an accommodation they have refused to provide.

DTA Online Guide: See **Appendix G** for links to the DTA's BEACON 5 Online Guide that apply to this section.

29 How do I ask DTA for an accommodation?

DTA is required to ask all clients if they have a disability and need an accommodation. A DTA worker is supposed to ask these questions at application and recertification, and also when a client raises disability. You can ask for an accommodation at any time that you need one.

You can ask your DTA case worker directly for an accommodation, or you can ask them to connect you to a Client Assistance Coordinator (CAC) for an accommodation.

- Each DTA local office has a CAC who can help with the accommodation process and other disability related needs. You should explain why the disability means you need the accommodation you are requesting.

- Once you ask for an accommodation, DTA should work with you to figure out what accommodation is appropriate. For example, if you ask for something DTA says they cannot do, instead of denying your request, they should discuss other options with you.

DTA does not usually ask for medical proof that you need the accommodation. If DTA does ask for proof, you can ask the Client Assistance Coordinator to help you get it.

Go to DTA's webpage, [Help for Applicants & Clients with Disabilities](#), for a list of Client Assistance Coordinators in each local DTA office.

30 What are my rights if DTA denies my reasonable accommodation?

It is unusual for DTA to deny a request for reasonable accommodation. If DTA cannot approve the specific accommodation you ask for, they should discuss what they can do for you. If DTA has not approved the accommodation you think you need, though, you have the right to appeal.

The DTA local office should give you a written decision on your request for reasonable accommodation no later than 30 days from your request. If DTA denies your request, or any part of it, you can ask the DTA Central Office Accommodation Appeal Committee to review the local office decision by filling out the back of the form and giving it to your worker.

The Committee has 10 days to decide on the reconsideration request. You can also file your request directly with the Committee if the local office does not decide on your request in 30 days.

If the DTA Central Office Accommodation Appeal Committee denies your request for accommodation in whole or in part or does not make a decision in 10 days from your request for a decision, you can request a hearing by filling out the back of the form and sending it to the Division of Hearings.

To get help with your request for review and/or your appeal, see **Appendix E** for a list of Legal Services offices. See also **Part 6** on your appeal rights.

DTA Online Guide: See **Appendix G** for links to the DTA's BEACON 5 Online Guide that apply to this section.

31 How can the DTA Ombuds Office help?

DTA has a special DTA Ombuds Office to handle client complaints and concerns. You can call the Ombuds Office any time you need help fixing your SNAP case.

DTA Ombuds Office: 617-348-5354

If you hear the voicemail recording, leave a detailed message with your full name, your DTA Agency ID or SSN, and a phone number where you can be reached. If you do not get help with your case, contact an advocate. You also have the right to appeal any decision made by DTA See **Part 6**.

32 What if I have concerns about my safety and access to my case information?

DTA can take steps to protect you from people who may try to harm you or steal your personal information two ways:

First, if you are concerned about safety or unauthorized persons accessing your information, ask DTA to **put a “block”** on getting case information from DTACConnect or the automated part of the DTA Assistance Line. You can still talk to a DTA worker over the phone or in person at a local DTA office, but you won’t be able to use DTACConnect or the automated Assistance Line. Call DTA at **1-877-382-2363** and ask a worker to put a block on “online services.” You can remove the block at any time by calling DTA.

Second, you can also ask DTA for a **“heightened level of security”** on your case. This means that DTA will put extra privacy protection on your case, which can be very important for victims of domestic violence or violent crimes. To ask about this extra level of security contact a Domestic Violence specialist at DTA.

DTA has Domestic Violence Specialists in each DTA office to assist individuals who are experiencing DV. For information on how to connect with a specialist, go to [DTA Domestic Violence Services](#).

You can also talk to a DV specialist through a Zoom video call from your personal computer/smartphone or at a local DTA office. Tell a DTA worker or the DV specialist if you want a virtual Zoom call.

33 What is a Photo EBT card and who needs to have one?

Most cash and SNAP households do have a photo on their EBT card because they are “exempt” from the state’s photo EBT rule (see below).

Photo or no photo, you and your SNAP household members have the *same rights* when using the

EBT card to buy food at a grocery store, farmers market or online purchasing. The back of each DTA EBT card states: “This card may be used by any household member.” Remember, the PIN is your electronic signature and secures the card. Do not share the PIN with anyone outside of your SNAP household.

NOTE: The EBT photo card *cannot be used as a government-issued ID* for any legal purposes such as boarding an airplane, entering state or federal buildings, opening a bank account, purchasing cigarettes or alcohol, or other activities that require a government-issued ID. Photo EBT cards do *not* include the household’s address, SSN, or date of birth.

Here are images of the DTA EBT cards DTA has issued over the years in Massachusetts. The dark blue card is the current design DTA started issuing in 2025. All of these cards are accepted by EBT retailers if the household has a balance in their account to spend.



EBT customer rights at stores

- Stores must allow all SNAP household members to use the card, whether or not their name or picture is on the EBT card.
- Stores may not set up “SNAP-only” checkout lines nor refuse to let you use self-checkout lines.
- Store clerks must not treat SNAP recipients differently from other shoppers who use credit or debit cards.
- Stores must not ask to see your photo EBT card unless it is the store policy to ask for ID of all debit or credit card customers.

Federal rules protect the right of all authorized members to use the EBT card and to not be discriminated against: [7 C.F.R. §274.7\(a\)](#), [7 C.F.R. §274.8\(b\)\(5\)\(ii\)](#) and [7 §C.F.R..278.2\(b\)](#).

Households EXEMPT from photo EBT card

You do not need a photo EBT card if you are the head of household (the person whose name is on the card) and you are:

- Age 60 or older
- Disabled or blind
- Under age 19
- Homeless
- A victim of domestic violence
- A person with a sincerely held religious belief.

DTA also does not issue photo EBT cards for authorized representatives nor for adults applying on behalf of their eligible dependents but *not applying for* themselves, such as an ineligible parent applying on behalf of eligible children.

If you have a photo EBT card but you later became exempt from the photo EBT rules (for example, you turn age 60 or become disabled), you can ask for a “Valid-without-photo” EBT card. DTA should issue you a new EBT card without a photo and not charge you any replacement fee.

DTA Online Guide: See **Appendix G** for links to the DTA’s BEACON 5 Online Guide that apply to this section.